

Organization

Dr. Christian A. Mahringer

TUM School of Management, Campus Heilbronn



Session 00

Introduction to the course “Organization”

About your lecturer

Dr. Christian A. Mahringer

Vita:

- Researcher, educator, and speaker on strategy, organization, and innovation in the digital transformation of work.
- PhD at the University of Stuttgart, 2015 – 2019.
- Senior researcher at the University of Stuttgart, since 2020.
- Led an interdisciplinary research project on processes of change at the Heidelberg Academy of Sciences and Humanities, 2021 to 2025.
- Guest lecturer at TUM, since 2026.

Research themes:

- AI and organizing
- Organizational routines
- Digital transformation
- Organizing for innovation
- Micro-level, practice-theoretical approach



Why organization matters

When coordination and accountability fail, consequences escalate quickly

- Two crashes in India and Ethiopia killed 346 people and led to a worldwide grounding of the aircraft.
- Investigations pointed not only to technical problems, but also to weak transparency, unclear accountability, and insufficient oversight (“culture of concealment”).
- Organization therefore shapes whether critical information is noticed, escalated, and acted on in time.
- **Takeaway:** Organization is part of the system that enables reliable and responsive action, but which may also lead to failure.

Case: Boeing 737 MAX



<https://www.bbc.com/news/business-54174223>;
Image source: pixabay, Robert_LA

Why organization matters

When information moves well, firms adapt faster and execute better

- Zara built a highly responsive design, production, and distribution system that is tightly linked to continuous feedback from stores.
- Its centralized distribution system delivers stores twice per week, enabling local demand information to be translated into operational decisions within days.
- New products can move from concept to store in approximately 10 to 15 days, allowing continuous adjustment based on demand.
- **Takeaway:** Good organization creates an information processing advantage. It improves speed, coordination, and implementation quality.

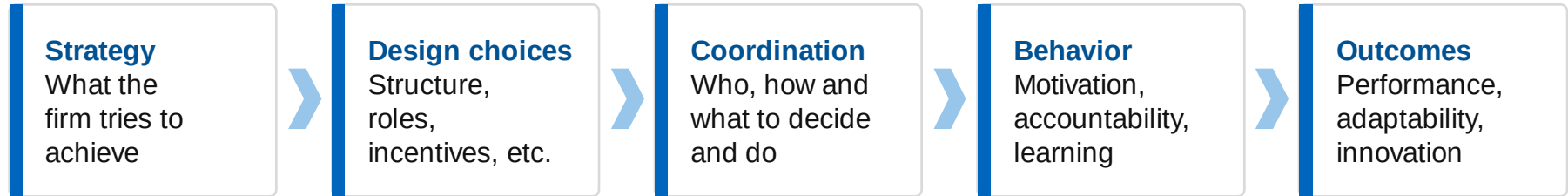
Case: Zara



[https://www.thefuturefactory.com/insights/zara-lean-supply-chain-agility;](https://www.thefuturefactory.com/insights/zara-lean-supply-chain-agility)
Image source: pexels.com, Elina Volkova

What this course helps you understand

Organization links strategy to outcomes through concrete design choices



Realm of organization theory

Prototypical questions in the module

- What are the implications of strategy for organizing?
- How do formal and informal organization shape actual work?
- What are the means through which organizations remain stable, or change over time?

Takeaway: The module provides concepts and perspectives for analyzing how organizations are designed, how they work, and why they succeed or fail.

Learning goals

Conceptual understanding

Explain central concepts of organization theory, including structure, coordination, incentives, routines, culture, and change.

Analytical application

Use concepts to analyze organizational problems, cases, and design choices in a structured way.

Critical comparison

Compare alternative organizational arrangements and assess their strengths, limits, and contingencies.

Theory-practice linkage

Connect concepts to empirical cases and current developments such as AI, agility, and platforms.

Argumentation

Develop precise, evidence-based arguments about organization.

Exam readiness

Prepare to solve both conceptual and applied exam questions across lecture and exercise content.

Structure of the course

Each listed session includes lecture plus exercise

Date	Main theme
13.04.2026	Definitional basics of organization
20.04.2026	Formal organizational design
27.04.2026	Organization and environment
04.05.2026	Strategic organization design
11.05.2026	Technology and organization
18.05.2026	Information technology, AI, and organization
01.06.2026	Informal organization

Date	Main theme
08.06.2026	Informal organization
15.06.2026	Dynamic perspectives on organizing
22.06.2026	Guest lecture, Felix Ehrenfels, mmmake
06.07.2026	Trends in organization design
13.07.2026	Trends in organization design
17.07.2026	Review and wrap-up

Structure of the course

Three complementary formats

Lecture

Conceptual and theoretical foundations; core concepts and explanatory frameworks.



Exercise

Application to exercises and cases; transfer of concepts to concrete organizational problems.



Tutorial, virtual

Space to ask questions and clarify issues.

Recommended use

Attend lecture and exercise as one unit, then use the tutorial to close knowledge gaps while topics are still fresh (when needed).

Structure of the course



Weekly rhythm

Lecture and exercise

Mondays, 14:15 to 17:45

Tutorial, online

Every Tuesday from 14.04.2026 to 14.07.2026,
08:15 to 09:45

Zoom link:

<https://us02web.zoom.us/j/83015571386?pwd=WgobYlWq9LNWvrWOuKMkaif5wIOwyS.1>

Zoom room code: 291884

Important exceptions

No lecture and exercise on 29.06.2026

Additional session on 17.07.2026

Rules of the game

What helps the course work well for everyone

Active participation

Contribute questions, ideas, and observations during lecture, exercise, and tutorial.

Preparation

Use the agenda to keep track of the semester structure and upcoming topics. Complete homework assignments.

Constructive interaction

Discuss arguments critically, but respectfully and professionally.

Ask early

Use the tutorial to clarify difficulties before they accumulate.

Connect theory and cases

Take notes that link concepts, examples, and exercise solutions.

Feedback welcome

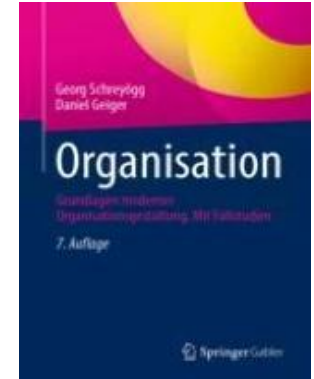
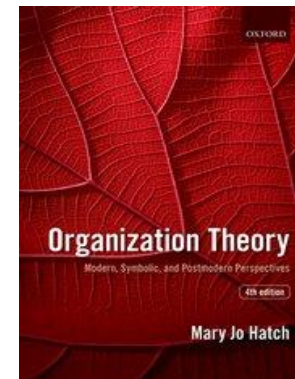
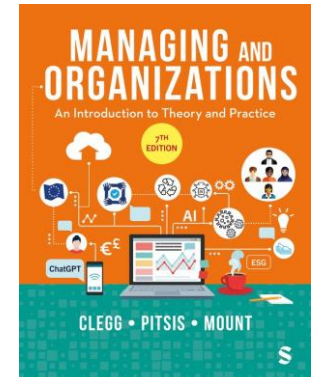
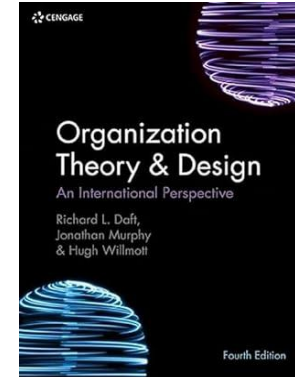
If something can be improved, please say so in a constructive way.

Literature recommendations

The lecture does not map exactly onto a single textbook.
Slides usually contain references for further reading.

Recommended readings

- Daft, R. L., Murphy, J., & Willmott, H. (2022). Organization theory and design: An international perspective (4th ed.). Cengage.
- Hatch, M. J. (2018). Organization theory: Modern, symbolic, and postmodern perspectives (4th ed.). Oxford University Press.
- Clegg, S. R., Pitsis, T. S., & Mount, M. (2025). Managing and organizations: An introduction to theory and practice (7th ed.). Sage.
- Schreyögg, G., & Geiger, D. (2024). Organisation: Grundlagen moderner Organisationsgestaltung (7th ed.). Springer.
(This book is in German, but the other books should be sufficient)



Exam information

What to expect in the exam

Format

Exam language: English
Duration: 60 minutes

Scope

Everything covered in the course is relevant, including the guest lecture.

Materials

All lecture slides will be uploaded.

- Questions relate both to conceptual content and to applied exercises.
- Example questions:
 - Name and explain the definitional criteria of an organization.
 - Assess whether “Fridays for Future” is an organization according to this definition.
- The exam tests understanding, application, and transfer.
- For exercise parts, there are usually no singular solutions, but your solutions will be provided on Moodle.

Guest lecture

Planned session in the course agenda

Topic: Skills as the New Currency of Organizations

Date: 22.06.2026

Lecturer: Felix Ehrenfels, mmmake

Teaser: As organizations become faster, flatter, and more project-based, traditional job architectures are no longer enough. This session explores how companies can shift from role-based thinking to skill-based organizing: identifying critical capabilities, increasing internal mobility, and aligning talent decisions with business strategy. From an organizational psychology perspective, we will also look at the impact on motivation, identity, fairness, and employability.



How to prepare for the course



- Review the agenda early so you understand the semester structure and how topics build on each other.
- Attend lecture and exercise together, because key concepts are applied directly on the same day.
- Use the tutorial to clarify difficulties early, especially when a concept, framework, or case logic remains unclear.
- When a slide topic feels difficult or especially interesting, follow the references on the slides.
- Take notes that connect concepts, examples, and exercise applications.
- Keep up continuously. Exam preparation is easier when you revisit material each week instead of starting late.
- Pay attention to the guest lecture, because it is part of the examinable course content.

Contact information



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